CASE STUDY

VIVEK PATIL, 30, *Mumbai*

WHAT HAPPENED

I've been involved in two serious accidents. The first occurred in 2017 when I crashed my bike into a tree after failing to navigate a sharp turn on way to Lavasa in early hours. That left me with a broken ankle that later required surgery. More recently, on July 4, while riding along Mumbai's coastal road, an oil spill of sorts caused my bike to skid. While I was safe, my friend who was riding pillion suffered a head injury. Locals informed us we were the eighth accident at that spot that day.

HOW HIGHWAYS CAN BE MADE SAFE

These experiences have made me perpetually cautious on all roads. There's a critical need for alerts about sharp bends or hazardous road conditions like oil spills. Highways should also have more accessible information about roadside assistance and proper post-accident protocols.



MANDAR DEODHAR

State governments were asked to make these mandatory and the process began with government-owned vehicles and then to privately owned ones. So far, 17 states and Union Territories have implemented these norms. Close to 60 registered vehicle scrapping centres have come up in these 17 states and UTs; 12 have 75 automated testing centres.

MoRTH has also imposed strict norms on vehicle manufacturers to protect the occupants of a vehicle in the event of frontal and lateral collisions. Fitment of front airbags for drivers was made mandatory from 2019 onward and for passengers in the front seat for all vehicles from 2021 onwards. Gadkari has also pushed for six airbags to be installed in cars to protect backseat passengers too, though manufacturers are reluctant as it will push up costs. Meanwhile, the fitment of safety technologies, including anti-lock braking system, has been made mandatory for all four-wheelers besides seatbelt reminders for driver and co-driver, overspeed warning systems, reverse parking sensors and manual override for central locking of doors. To prevent overspeeding by commercial vehicles on highways, the ministry has mandated that all transport vehicles have speed limiting functions or devices.

From October 2023, MoRTH also started the Bharat New Car Assessment Programme (BNCAP), which assigns a star rating for vehicles with eight or fewer seats for adult and child occupation protection and safety assist technology to help customers decide which cars have the best safety features. Buses with a 22-passenger capacity have to comply with fire detection alarm and suppression systems. Buses, trucks and trailers must also mandatorily have reflective tapes on the front, rear and sides so that they are better visible at night.

RECKLESS DRIVERS, LAX ENFORCEMENT

All these, however, could come to nought without strict enforcement of traffic safety rules on highways. "It is very rare to find cars on highways that follow lane driving. I think most people don't even know what highway driving rules are," says Ramesh Kumar, author of *10,000 Km on the Indian Highways*. That is because most people do not go to a driving school to learn driving and it is the easiest to get a licence in this country. Reckless driving, drunken driving, overspeeding and driving on the wrong side of the road are also common.

Experts say that speed monitors need to be placed on more stretches and monitored strictly, with steep penalties not just for overspeeding but also for driving in the wrong direction, driving at low speed or incorrect overtaking. This is how rules are enforced on some of the safest highways in the world like in the Netherlands, Singapore and Norway.

India is making an effort too. Since 2019, the Motor Vehicles Act, 1988, has been frequently amended to tighten norms, including stricter penalties for deterrence. The penalty for drunken driving has increased from Rs 2,000 to Rs 10,000 and suspension of licence. Licences are also impounded and suspended for those driving dangerously, including overspeeding. The latest equipment is being installed across all highways to electronically monitor traffic flow and impose penalties for violations. There is some movement on the driving licence front too. The Centre has issued norms for states to set up authorised driving schools with simulators and dedicated test driving centres. These need to be rapidly implemented.